

# Tips for Grown-Ups

## Helping Kids Learn About Boundaries, Consent, and Permission



### Dear adults,

Some little kids enjoy physical contact more than others, and that's okay! Especially if you have a child in your life who likes to hug, hold hands, or otherwise touch other people, it might help to have some conversations with them about boundaries, consent, and permission. This is especially helpful if they'll be heading into a situation with new kids, like a classroom or a birthday party.

Here are some ideas to cover these topics with your kids in ways they will understand:

### 1 Start with a discussion.

Explain what the words boundaries, consent, and permission mean, and help them get comfortable with saying, "Can I have a hug?" Have the child repeat things back to you. Ask questions like, "So tell me, what can we do when we meet someone? And what should we not do?" Brainstorm with your child what alternatives might be good for a friend who doesn't like to be touched, like high fives or waving. (See the "For Kids" worksheet for more ideas on ways to start a conversation about consent with your child.)



### 2 Model through play.

Many young kids learn better through play. You can try to work similar scenarios into your natural play (i.e., pretend you're a new friend and act out what they'd say in that situation), or use family members to help act out the scene.



### 3 Provide visuals.

Reading books about consent is a great way to introduce the concept. You can also pull up pictures online of safe alternatives to hugs, like high fives and handshakes. Print out photos of different facial expressions to help kids understand what another child's body language might be telling them.



\*A special thank you to Stephanie Lock, a school counselor in Goshen, New York, for her help with this advice for kids and parents on consent!\*

### 4 Practice, practice, practice!

Don't expect your child — especially young children — to understand and remember everything after one chat. These are big concepts! Remind them frequently of the rules, as well as why they're important.

